

to understand why students leave their financial problems to chance. If you feel you don't have any control over the situation, why bother?

A teenager, Kirk, once told me that after he stopped paying his gym club membership fees, he was harassed with bills for a while but then they stopped coming. Kirk was relieved that the problem had gone away. It wasn't until years later that he discovered an unpaid account on his credit report. Kirk was sure it was a mistake since he didn't recognize the company to whom he supposedly owed money. In fact, it was the collection agency that had received his account after the gym club gave up trying to collect from Kirk. His problem hadn't disappeared after all!

Problems ignored usually become larger problems. If a problem is dealt with early enough, many times the situation is easily resolved. But you can be assured that the longer you ignore it, the greater the probability that it will escalate into a confrontation with less favorable solutions. And if you avoid the situation for a long enough period of time, you may lose the privilege to negotiate or compromise at all. You may find that the final decision will be made unilaterally without your input and you will be stuck with the end result whether you like it or not.

This chapter will illustrate the actions and problems faced by young adults who choose to remain in denial of their money problems. The following subjects will be covered:

- Ignoring bills
- Avoiding collectors
- Contacting collectors
- Avoiding repossession and other losses
- Letting others control your finances
- Making only minimum payments
- Avoiding debt through gambling

